3.5- Stages of socialization

Learning objectives

- Define different stages of socialization process
- Explain the role of major agencies of socialization and nature of social learning that occurs at each stage
- Discuss various theoretical perspectives related to sequential process of socialization from childhood to adulthood

Learning outcomes

- Explain different stages of socialization and their relevance in human development
- Describe the major characteristics of each stages and relate them with real life examples
- Analyze different theoretical perspectives related to socialization and identify major agencies active in each stage of the socialization

Introduction

Socialization is a lengthy and continuous learning process. A baby does not grasp all the social regulations at the same time, but rather starts with basic, small lessons and slowly goes to more complicated ones. Their social world is very limited in early childhood. Socialization at its basic level is a process by which children learn to "play" different social roles (e.g., brother, student, friend). In order to do this, they have to internalize-not only their own roles-but also the roles of other people around them. As they mature, this world becomes bigger with the addition of school, friends, and society. With every new stage, they encounter new challenges and have to get used to more rules, expectations, and relationships. The stages of socialization are like layers of identity, just like one heap up the next one. By acquiring and integrating these roles, kids become people capable of operating in their families, communities, and society.

Stages of socialization

Socialization, similarly to other aspects of human development - cognitive, emotional, moral - has a recognizable structure and sequence. The pace and exact content may be different due to culture, personality, or environment, but the general direction is from dependence to autonomy, from concrete to abstract understanding, and from familial intimacy to broader societal participation. Following that, we consider the major psychological theories that dissect the socialization process, thus explaining how interaction, instruction, and experience lead to the development of personality, identity, and social competence.

According to Sigmund Freud “The Psychosexual Foundations of Personality” one of the most prominent works of Sigmund Freud, is his model of psychosexual development. It draws attention to the very important matter of how the first years of one's life immensely affect one's personality, ability to regulate emotions and behave in society. Freud claimed that man development goes through five different stages of which are biologically determined and each stage is specific to a certain erogenous zone and also accompanied with the occurrence of

psychological conflicts between id (instinctual) drives, ego (reality), and superego (moral) ones.

I. Sigmund Freud: The Tripartite structure of personality and Psycho-sexual development

Freud believed that human actions are mainly influenced by unconscious biological impulses that are basically of a sexual and aggressive nature. Along these lines, these instincts need to be controlled, changed, or suppressed if they are to co-exist with social norms. In his conception, socialization does not mean cooperating or taking each other's roles, rather it is a process of taming one's inner-demons for civilized life to be feasible.

The Three-Part Self: Id, Ego, and Superego

Freud outlined three parts of the human mind which work together to form the personality. These parts are the id, the ego, and the superego, and they have different functions and sources of motivation.

1. The Id - The Pleasure Principle

The id is the part of a person's psyche, which is the most primitive and has been there since the time of one's birth. It totally obeys the pleasure principle, which means, it is always after it seeks the immediate satisfying of the needs and wants of a human body that are the most basic- for example, hunger, thirst, and sex- but it does so totally disregarding the consequences of its actions, moral principles, or reality. Once these desires get fulfilled, tension subsides, and pleasure comes. The id is irrational, it acts on impulse, and it is in the subconscious- it demands that it be satisfied immediately, regardless of the surroundings.

Example: A hungry baby will not stop crying until it is fed - it does not know how to wait for its turn or figure out whether the time is right for eating.

2. The Ego - The Reality Principle

The ego is development one in the short period of the early childhood years that aims at helping reconcile the id's demands with the outer world. It is supported by the reality principle and is, therefore, able to find ways that are acceptable socially to satisfy the needs of the id usually by delay, substitution, or compromise.

One can relate the ego to being a "traffic controller" - the ego looks into the situations, calculates the results of the options and picks the one that is the most right, the most secure, or the most effective in which to act. For example, if the id demands food, the ego could stop the child from taking somebody else's food forcefully or eating something that is harmful to the body (like a poisonous berry), by waiting until it is possible to eat or to get safe food the right way.

The ego is mainly a logical and conscious part of the mind- nevertheless, it also has the ability to use defense mechanisms (such as repression or denial) to deal with internal conflict.

3. The Superego- The Moral Principle

The superego is the result of incorporation of the morals of the parents and the norms of the society which happens in the age of 5-6 years. It is the conscience that, on the one hand, supports the correct behaviours by pride, and on the other, punishes the wrong ones by guilt or shame.

In his description, Freud compared the superego to an internalized parent, which is always evaluating the person's actions on the basis of morals. According to these moral standards the judgments made, these evaluations at first concern only the family but then the set of cultural norms become the supreme judge. The superego seeks ultimate perfection- mostly unrealistically- and it even keeps the ego in-check, as per every thought and deed.

Example: A lying child could experience guilt in intensity - not because of being caught but because its superego condemns lying.

In his work, Freud visualized the development of personality as an unfolding in a series of psychosexual stages where each stage is associated with a different erogenous zone- a part of the body, which becomes the main source of pleasure and the psychological focus during that period. He also believed that healthiness in growth depends on the successful management of conflicts that come from each stage- especially the ones between the child's instinctual drives (id) and the demands coming from outside parents, and later, the internalized superego.

If one fails to resolve these issues, the result may be fixation- that is the remaining of a close association with the behaviours or the attitudes of that stage, which eventually can shape the personality and the behaviour of the adult.

If a person manages to move through these stages successfully his personality will be healthy and well-developed; otherwise, there might be a deep-seated behavioural patterns or neuroses that will be with the person throughout his life. Even though Freud's theory has been disputed and is seen to be very much dependent on the culture of the time, it is still the stepping stone for a deeper insight into the social identity and interpersonal relationships that are affected not only by the early familial dynamics but also by the unconscious aspects of human nature.

Stage 1: Oral Stage (Birth -1 Year)

Oral stage is the first stage and it includes the time since birth till the child is about one year. The oral stage is the one that attaches the baby’s mouth to the most important source of pleasure and new relations. After the baby comes to the world, it has to be able to deal with new challenges such as breathing, eating, and keeping warm. The baby if hungry, cold, or wet complains by crying. In this way, the baby learns to be dependent on the adults who take care of it - especially for feeding. They want food at certain times, so they start to use crying to communicate their needs. To infants, the world is a very enjoyable place since they have the ability to suck, bite and swallow - not only to satisfy them but also for emotional comfort and bonding. It is a well-known fact that babies calm themselves by sucking a pacifier or thumb - thus proving how oral stimulation can be used as a way of emotional comfort besides satisfying hunger.

At this time, the baby acquires its first social bond - normally with the mother- associating this by eating, touching, and giving/receiving care. Before the language emerges, communication is done only through crying, smiling, and physical gestures. The baby is usually considered by the members of the family as a "focus of care" rather than an independent person. If another person (for example, the father) is providing the care, the child can regard this person as a “mother figure.” As they grow, children start identifying and emotionally responding to other family members who show care and are there for them consistently.

Psychologist Sigmund Freud called this the stage of “primary identification.” This means the baby feels deeply connected to their caregiver, almost as if they are one. They haven’t yet realized that they are different persons. The baby’s main objective is to satiate hunger and relieve discomfort by making a bond with their caregiver.

Socialization indeed starts here- not by means of rules or roles but trust, dependency, and emotional reciprocity.

Stage 2: Anal Stage (1 – 3 Years)

The anal stage comes after the first year and continues until the third year of human life. The time that a child grows up and is less dependent on the mother or father is especially important to the child's development and psychological growth. The toilet training gradually becomes the primary means of mental and social development. Kids begin to take control of themselves by learning to do various things - dress properly, eat by themselves, and do the toilet.

The parents have double roles:

- Direct reaction: Parental instruction and facilitation of the child’s daily routine.
- Social system participator: Imparting the family laws and norms to the young one.

While this parental double role exposes the child to the challenge of finding the right mixture between his/ her personal necessities and the existing societal regulations, it is a harmonious game of mastering the rules. The mother or father at times can indulge in the child’s whish (e.g., by allowing the child to prolong the playtime) and, at the same time, set limits (e.g., reminder of the necessity to maintain personal hygiene). This relation enables the child to be at ease with different social groups other than just his/her parents.

The moment seals the opening to the social world with the issues of standard behavioural norms, discipline, and delayed gratification. Parents, particularly moms as per Freud’s opinion, are the pivots of the child’s socialization changes and play the roles of the cheerleader and the limit-setter in the process, “”Good job!”” and “”No, stop!””. The child gains these concepts through this negotiating dynamic:

• The difference between “right” and “wrong” behaviours

• The ways of managing social demands while controlling their impulses

• To recognize that love and approval depend on their obedience sometimes

On a related note, Freud was of the opinion that the manner in which parents carry out toilet training i.e., whether they are strict or permissive, would be instrumental in the emergence of a person's character traits in the future - those who are over-controlling or those who are untidy and rebellious.

The child meets for the first time with the framework of society - and gets the first basic lessons in self-control and social conformity - through the anal stage.

Stage 3: Phallic / Oedipal Stage (3 – 6 Years)

It is the time from about 3 year to 6 year, i.e. before the middle childhood (latency period). Freud argued that children at this level seek very close bonds with the parents of the opposite sex and at the same time show hostility and rivalry against the parents of the same sex.

- Oedipus Complex (in boys): A male child may develop love for the mother and envy of the father and consider him as a rival for the mother's attention.
- Electra Complex (in girls): A female child could develop that love for the father and the jealousy against the mother, considering the latter to be a rival.

During this phase, children suppress their desires and instead follow the same-sex parent's values, behaviours, and gender role, which they have internalized. The stage is extremely important for gender socialization. Boys are pushed to do what is expected from a typical boy and girls, likewise, as a girl must be. Through encouragement, imitation, and covert support kids learn the socially acceptable gender norms that they are not usually aware of. In addition, according to Freud this is a point where the child totally adopts the cultural symbolic world - accepts cultural rules, taboos, and morals.

Stage 4: Latency Stage (Ages 6 - Puberty)

After the highly disputed phallic stage, kids undergo a period of peace - latency stage. Sexual desires are repressed or are in a dormant state, and vigour is redirected to social, intellectual, and skill-earning activities such as school, friendships, and hobbies, as well as sports.

Stage 5: Genital Stage (Puberty - Adulthood)

Once puberty arrives, sexual energy is recharged - this time focusing on mature, heterosexual relationships and genital intimacy. Freud regarded this as the last and most mature stage, where individuals, in a perfect scenario, achieve a balance between id, ego, and superego.

Adults, with the help of successful navigation through the earlier stages, are capable of forming stable romantic relationships, pursuing meaningful work, and making positive contributions to society. People who are stuck in the stages of their earlier life may find it difficult to engage in intimacy, may have problems with authority, or lack in their self-regulation.

During adolescence, biological maturation leads to the reawakening of sexual energy, but this time, it is directed toward peers and romantic partners - ideally, in ways that are accepted by the society.

Main social dynamics include:

- Peer influence increases substantially - adolescents look for approval, identity, and a sense of belonging outside the family
- Battle for independence - teenagers usually resist parental control and thus, many conflicts arise
- Role testing - experimenting with new identities, values, styles, and behaviours
- Taking in adult norms - getting ready for the future as workers, partners, citizens
- Parents keep being influential - they monitor, guide, and sometimes clash with their children but friends, media, schools, and subcultures have more and more influence over the children's values and self-concept.

So, adolescence is not so much about biological drives, but more about social redefinition - becoming an independent, socially integrated adult.

II- Stages of Socialization: According to George Herbert Mead

American sociologist and philosopher George Herbert Mead (1934) argued that the self is a development that cannot be detached from the larger socialization process that he perceived as an interactive and communicative journey of a lifetime, among other things, role-taking and symbolic understanding. In his view, the 'self' is definitely not inborn but rather it comes from social experience or the continuous engagement with other people.
Nevertheless, Mead advanced the point by situating his self-concept theory into a bigger picture of socialization which he described as a lifelong and ever-changing process. He pointed out that the self is not just a mirror of other people's views but a construct that evolves through the individuals' engagement in social roles, use of language and symbolic communication.

At the core of the theory is the conception of the self as comprising two interrelated elements:

- The “I”: The unstructured, original, creative, and sometimes reckless part of the self- it depicts the individual's most direct and unmediated reaction to society and other people. It is the place where the ideas of agency, innovation, and personal expression originate from.
- The “Me”: The socialized self - a psychological image made by importing the view of significant others (parents, brothers, sisters and best friends) on us into one's own perspective. It mirrors social norms and functions as the inner guide for one's conduct.

The “I” confronts the “Me”- thus establishing an ongoing conversation inside one's mind where one's personal urges are in touch with social rules. It is this fluctuating state of the “I” (spontaneity) and the “Me” (conformity) that constitutes the core of human identity.

Mead argued that this complicated self was not the child's immediate conception but rather it came to be through the imitation, play, and game developmental stages. Moreover, the stages signify the levels of social understanding and symbolic skills through which the child gradually becomes capable of internalizing social roles and developing a consistent sense of self.

Stage 1: Imitation stage- Mimicking without meaning

At the very first phase, children practice mere imitation - they imitate adult hand gestures, sounds, or actions without understanding their social significance. A toddler may run a toy vacuum over the floor as if "helping" a parent with the cleaning - not because they understand the work that goes into cleaning a house, but because they are copying the behaviour they have seen.

Here, the idea of role-taking is absent; the child does not have the mental capacity necessary for interpreting the meaning behind the actions. Imitation is an instinctive one and not thought-through, however, it is this stage that initiates the process of social learning which will later become more intentional.

Stage 2: Play Stage - Stepping into roles

The next stage is the play stage which happens when children develop the ability to see that characters in the play are connected to certain social roles, e.g. doctor, teacher, superhero or firefighter. Through play children become creative and symbolic: they no longer simply copy an adult- they actually take on the role of a certain character.

One of the popular examples is the play with dolls: a child can address the doll in a loving or harsh manner - imitating how a parent talks - and then change the role, replying as if the doll were a child, therefore, using the voice and the words of a child. This continuous exchange signifies a significant advancement: the child is starting to "take the role of the other."

The child by moving between different roles - parent and child, hero and villain, teacher and student - becomes able to view the world from various angles. They also start to relate their own thoughts and conduct to the ones that are socially shared- another important step in the formation of the self which is consistent.

The children, through this role-play, get the opportunity to harmonize their own ideas and actions with those that are shared by society. They start realizing that certain actions have definite social implications and they behave accordingly. It is specifically through this creative performance of social roles that kids get to know the different norms, expectations, and even emotional responses - thus, they are setting the pillars for the emergence of a mature self that is socially integrated.

Stage 3: Game Stage- Understanding the Generalized Other

According to Mead the most mature point is the game stage. Here, children no longer just assume the viewpoint of one person but are able to understand and adjust to the expectations of the whole group. Success then depends on, not only what one friend will do, but also on what the others will do.

Think of a child playing baseball:

- Every player has to fully comprehend not only their own duties but also the roles of the teammates, opponents as well the rules that are binding for everybody.
- The child starts to control his/her behaviour in line with the shared standards - when to run, when to stop, how to work together.

By involving in such group activities, children start to absorb the concept of what Mead referred to as "the generalized other"– the societal viewpoint which is not directed at one particular person but at all. They do not behave in response to only Mom or a best friend, instead, they evaluate their actions according to wider, non-personal criteria: "What would 'people' think?" or "Is this the way 'someone like me' should behave?"

By being taught to stick to the rules of a game children, actually, prepare themselves for living in society- where the rules are set by laws, customs, and moral codes. It is at the same point that children community identity- not only as individuals, but as part of a bigger community with common values and duties.

III- Stages of Socialization: According to Jean Piaget: The Cognitive foundations of social learning

Jean Piaget, a Swiss psychologist, is most famous for his theory of cognitive development. His research has significant effects on the understanding of socialization. Piaget maintained that the ability of children's learning - social norms, moral reasoning, and cultural symbols - to be learned is limited and influenced by their stage of cognitive maturity. To put it another way, the level of socialization a child can absorb is the one that corresponds to the level of their mental understanding.

Piaget saw cognitive development as going through four stages that are universal, sequential. These children stages are ordered the same for all kids, however, factors like the pace of development, degree of mastery, individual differences, and cultural context can have an impact on the level of each child's performance. At each stage, the child is provided with new neural resources - not only the content of thought is extended but the child becomes capable of new types of social interaction, interpretation and participation.

Stage 1: Sensorimotor Stage (Birth – 2 Years)

During this stage, devices of cognition in infants are their senses and motor skills, thus the world is made up of them to an infant through such activities as touching, grasping, tasting, and moving. Learning object permanence is another characteristics, the understanding that things exist even when unseen is considered a major achievement of this period.

An infant may see the act of hiding a toy under the blanket as the toy 'disappearing' and thus be upset when a parent leaves the room. as if the parent is no longer there.

This intellectual leap is at the root of socialization: it distinguishes the child to develop inner images of people and the relationships thus enabling the child to be prompted, to experience, and to emotionally bond- all necessary steps before social roles and norms can be learned.

Stage 2: Preoperational Stage (2 – 7 Years)

The main thrust of children's development during this time is their initiation into the use of symbols. They start representing objects and ideas through words, images, and make-believe.

While language develops to a high degree, and creativity is at its peak, children's thinking is still very much self-centred; they find it difficult to understand the viewpoints of others.

At the beginning of this stage one of the most significant shortcomings is symbolic confusion - not being able to distinctly separate a symbol from that which it signifies. For instance, a child may break down with tears if someone stomps on a sandcastle that has been referred to as 'my house,' thinking that the action is hurting their real home. However, by 6 or 7, they figure out that symbols are just signs, not reality.

The transformation is a turning point in socialization: through it, children get the ability to comprehend socially constructed meanings - flags, money, rituals, rules - which are intangible but of great cultural significance.

Stage 3: Concrete Operational Stage (7 – 11 Years)

At this point, kids are able to carry out mental operations - logical reasoning is limited to concrete, real things or events. They can classify, order, conserve quantities and are even able to reverse operations in their mind.

One classic example:

After showing a row of six sticks and asking to get the same number from a pile, a child at this stage is able to just count six without the need for one-to-one matching for each stick. Children younger than this and thus deprived of this skill have to physically place the sticks side by side in order to make sure that they are accurate.

The presence of logical and reversible thought here enables children to grasp concepts like fairness, rules, reciprocity, and cause-effect relationships in the social sphere, which, to be exact, are necessary skills for managing friendships, the classroom and the family environment.

Stage 4: Formal Operational Stage (12+ Years)

The next and last stage, formal operations, is reached at the beginning of adolescence. The thinking process here is abstract, hypothetical, and systematic. To give an instance, teens are able to ponder over the pros and cons of a moral dilemma (“Is it ever right to lie?”), envision the future, formulate and test scientific hypotheses, and draw logical conclusions about abstract concepts such as justice or freedom.

As an illustration, they may work through algebraic problems, take part in discussions regarding ethical issues (“Is it ever right to lie?”), or create future plans - all of which are grounded in their new-found capability for abstract and deductive reasoning. No later cognitive development is possible without this stage as a foundation.

Cognitive tools gained at this stage serve as a foundation for not only later intellectual but also social development - such as the ability for critical self-reflection, the holding of ideological commitments, and planning of long-term goals which are all necessary for adult roles in work, citizenship, and relationships.

Conclusion

Socialization, which is a process that is life-long, assists individuals in adjusting to society. It is born with a human and dies with him. As a person grows, he encounters different social situations and learns new roles. Psychologists and sociologists like Sigmund Freud, GH Mead, Jean Piaget- have been trying to figure out and explain this developmental journey, which is a map of the growth from dependence to maturity. They have drawn up stage models based on their own and others' observations and theories that indicate the manner and the reasons people become competent members of their social world at different stages of life.

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Check Your Progress

MCQ

1. The book 'The Psychosexual Foundations of Personality' authored by?

A) Sigmund Freud B) Jean Piaget

C) GH Mead D) Lundberg

2. The psychosexual development model proposed by

A) GH Mead B) Jean Piaget

C) Sigmund Freud D) Carl Rogers

3. According Freud, which structure of the personality operated on the pleasure principle

A) Id B) Ego

C) Super ego D) Cognitive

4. It is an organized part of the personality structure and which organize our thoughts as well as makes a sense of the reality around us.

A) Ego B) Id

C) Super ego D) Repression

5. The …… is mainly a logical and conscious part of the mind

A) Ego B) Super

C) ego D) Sublimation

6. Which structure of the personality operated on the morality principle

A) Super ego B) Id

C) Rationalization D) Ego

7. According to the Freud, which of the following is a primary stage of personality development?

A) Anal Stage B) Phallic Stage

C) Oral Stage D) Genital stage

8. What is the approximate age range for the Anal Stage of psychosexual development?

A) Birth to 1 year B) 3 to 6 years

C) 1 to 3 years D) 2 to 4 years

9. The conflict that arises in the Phallic Stage, where a boy develops sexual desires for his mother and views his father as a rival, is known as the……

A) Oedipus complex B) Regression

C) Moral anxiety D) Electra complex

10. A female child could develop that love for the father and the jealousy against the mother, considering the latter to be a rival. It is known as ……..

A) Electra complex B) Realistic anxiety

C) Oedipus complex D) Moral anxiety

11. According to Freud, Which of the following stage is characterised that a people develop skills, values and relationship with peers and adults outside the family

A) Latent stage B) Phallic stage

C) Genital stage D) Realistic stage

12. Which of the following sociologists suggest that self is not inborn but rather it comes from social experience or continuous interaction with other people

A) GH Mead B) Jean Piaget

C) Sigmund Freud D)Cooley

13. According to GH mead, the self as comprising two inter related elements, that are ……..

A) I and Me B) Oedipus and Electra complex

C) You and Me D) Emotion and Cognition

14. According to Mead, which of the following is an first stage of socialization?

A) Oral stage B) Imitation

C) Game stage D) Genital stage

15. Which of the following is not a stage of socialization proposed by GH Mead?

A) Imitation B) Play stage

C) Game stage D) Genital stage

16. Theory of cognitive development proposed by?

A) Jean Piaget B) GH Mead

C) Sigmund Freud D) Skinner

17. Which of the following theorist proposed that ability of children learning is limited and influenced by their stage of cognitive neutrality?

A) Jean Piaget B) Sigmund Freud

C) Albert Bandura D) GH mead

18. According to Piaget, which of the following is a primary stage of socialization?

A) Sensorimotor stage B) Preoperational stage

C) Concrete operational stage D) Formal operational stage

Short note

1. Define id, ego and super ego.
2. Discuss the two elements of the self-proposed by GH Mead.
3. Describe the primary characteristics of phallic stage.

Short Essay

1. Discuss different stage stages of socialization proposed by GH Mead
2. Describe cognitive foundations of social learning theory put forwarded by Jean Piaget

Essay

1. Define socialization and various stages of socialization process

MCQ Answers

1. A) Sigmund Freud
2. C) Sigmund Freud
3. A) Id
4. A) Ego
5. A) Ego

6. A) Super ego

7. C) Oral Stage

8. C) 1 to 3 years

9. A) Oedipus complex

10. A) Electra complex

11. A) Latent stage

12. A) GH Mead

13. A) I and Me

14. A) Oral stage

15. D) Genital stage

16. A) Jean Piaget

17. A) Jean Piaget

18. A) Sensorimotor stage

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